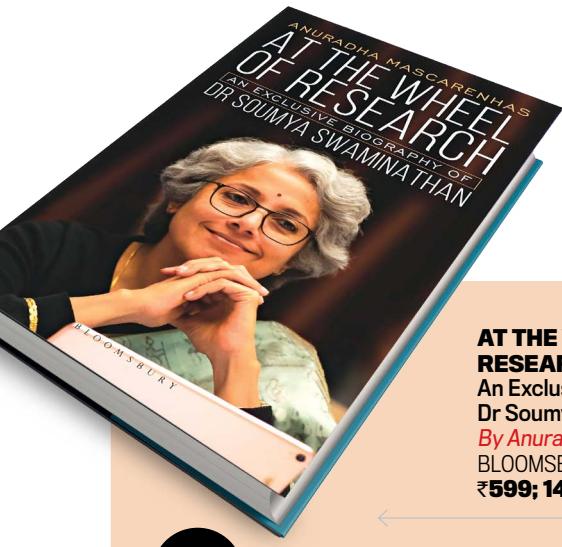
A Healthy Dose of Reading

Superbugs, superdocs and the pharma-industrial complex

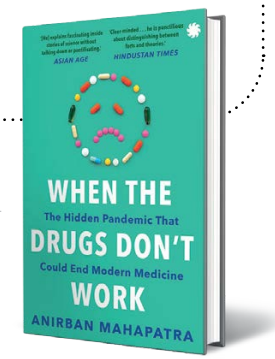


AT THE WHEEL OF RESEARCH
An Exclusive Biography of Dr Soumya Swaminathan
By Anuradha Mascarenhas
BLOOMSBURY INDIA
₹**599; 142** pages

In 2021, a tweet on the medication Ivermectin put Dr Soumya Swaminathan at the receiving end of trolling and even death threats. A former chief scientist at the WHO, former director of the NIRT and Indian Council of Medical Research, Dr Swaminathan's work in health research and medicine is legendary. Here, for the first time, readers can get to see the woman behind some extraordinary work and her vision for tuberculosis control, HIV treatment and reduction of inequalities in healthcare.

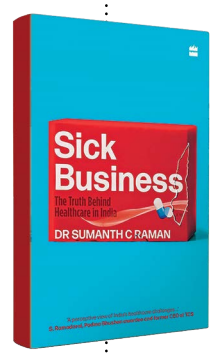
At the Wheel of Research includes anecdotes from her time studying for her MD in paediatrics at AIIMS to her days as head of India's premier research body, ICMR. It includes voices from her friends, work associates, sisters as well as her father, the legendary agronomist, M.S. Swaminathan. This is a chance to get to know what life is like for a female scientist living away from her husband, children and ageing parents as she leads a global health body in Geneva during a pandemic, and what value systems are needed to overcome career obstacles. ■

How do you make the reality of superbugs—bacteria that cannot be treated by medicine—relatable? There are, of course, the numbers. In 2019, superbugs were directly responsible for 300,000 deaths and indirectly for a million more in India. But Anirban Mahapatra's *When the Drugs Don't Work* goes a step further by whittling down the threat to an individual, almost experiential, level. Today, anyone who has poor immunity (like the 100 million or so diabetics in the country), needs to undergo a surgery, undergo chemotherapy, or even deliver a baby is at risk from superbugs. The remarkable pace and ingenuity with which bacteria are capitalising on mistakes made by humans in poultry farming, medical prescriptions and waste management, drives home the reality that this silent threat is at our own doorstep already. This book is an essential guide to the dangers that bacteria now pose to modern medicine and why steps like antibiotic stewardship and development of vaccines for superbugs are already essential for human survival. ■



WHEN THE DRUGS DON'T WORK
The Hidden Pandemic That Could End Modern Medicine
By Anirban Mahapatra
JUGGERNAUT
₹**599; 288** pages

It is never an easy task to find the right doctor when you are unwell, particularly given the hold of corporate pressure and big pharma in today's healthcare system. An internal medicine specialist with over 25 years of medical experience, Dr Sumanth C. Raman's book *Sick Business* is a much-needed guide to navigating healthcare in India. From health insurance, to finding a good doctor, to how to be a patient and how to choose a hospital—this book includes essential tips that can help make your diagnosis and treatment more effective and less stressful. Dr Raman includes experiences and insights on a profit-driven healthcare industry, doctor competency, negligence in government hospitals, medical ethics and shady research. Read this book to find out if you are being overtested, overdiagnosed or overtreated.



SICK BUSINESS
The Truth Behind Healthcare in India
By Dr Sumanth C. Raman
HARPERCOLLINS
₹**399; 304** pages

–Sonali Acharjee